

Young people face greater challenges today in being ready for the future. Discuss.

Key words:

Young people – those aged between 15 – 25 (children to late teens and young adults)

Greater challenges –increasing demands or obstacles

Today – the importance of the present-day context (characteristics of today's world) and how it impacts young people in terms of their preparedness for the future

Being ready for the future – being equipped both academically, emotionally and psychologically to face and to deal successfully with the uncertainty that characterises the future awaiting them.

Question type: Comparative (“greater”; today versus the past)

Possible stand:

Both sides are possible; this outline adopts the stand that young people face greater challenges today in being ready for the future (aligns more with reality).

Suggested Approach:

Part A: Some may argue that the young face fewer challenges in being ready for the future given how the world has changed.

Part B: However, there are greater challenges facing youth in being ready for the future, given how the world is changing.

Note: To do well, students should aim to use comparative language throughout the discussion.

Part A: Reasons why the young face fewer challenges in being ready for the future given how the world has changed.

A1. Compared to young people in the past, the young today are perceived to have better educational advantages which equip them with stronger academic qualifications and relevant life skills to prepare them for jobs for the future.

- Many young people are being schooled to higher levels, and especially with the array of online resources and information, they are able to develop critical thinking skills and they are more ready to deal with existing and new problems as they step into the future.

Example 1:

- Schools across the Western Balkans have introduced innovative teaching methodology to help students build the essential digital, problem solving and critical thinking skills needed for their future education and career. These 21st Century Schools offer access to training, equipment and materials, as well as providing a gateway to a network of schools across the Western Balkans and the UK. They offer support including training for school leaders to further develop their management and leadership skills and to help them effectively integrate and embed digital and core skills across existing national curricula. They also offer training and support for teachers across two core modules: digital skills, which focuses on incorporating digital literacy into the curriculum, and using digital tools for learning, communication and collaboration; and critical thinking and problem solving, which focuses

on improving student self-directed thinking and learning to produce new and innovative ideas that will empower them to be effective working adults in future.

Example 2:

Since its inception, Singapore's education system has been designed in tandem with the manpower needs of our economy. MOE does not go online to pick the most well-marketed curriculum; it speaks to our Ministry of Manpower and other ministries in determining what skills are most relevant when it comes time for our children to enter the workforce.

One key example is Singapore government's effort to ensure an inclusive digital society and the CFF (coding programme called Code For Fun) which will help to cultivate local talents for the emerging digital economy. This programme conducted by the Ministry of Education and Infocomm Media Development Authority (IMDA) was introduced to all primary schools in 2020 and it aims to expose young Singaporeans to core computational and coding concepts through simple visual programmes. Other programmes include Singapore Cyber Youth Programme (SG Cyber Youth) and an advanced version of Youth Cyber Exploration Programme (YCEP). These programmes target secondary and tertiary school students interested in a career related to cybersecurity. SG Cyber Youth aims to reach out to 10,000 students in the next three years.

This point on education making life easier for the young in the future was included by most candidates who attempted this question.

Part B: Reasons why there are greater challenges facing youth in being ready for the future, given how the world is changing.

B1. However, having better educational advantages is becoming inadequate as a requirement for future jobs because career success in the future will require young people to possess even more life skills such as strong socio-emotional skills besides academic prowess for them to be prepared for the future/successful.

- At present, young people are focussing on academics to an unhealthy degree, striving to prepare for the best jobs in the upcoming future from their early adolescent years in the belief that good grades will help them to be ready to face the future.

- However, the changing uncertainty that characterises our world today, including the job landscape, makes it clear that life skills like socio-emotional skills are going to be just as, if not more important, for young people to succeed in facing the challenges of the future.

-Furthermore, better educational opportunities alone may not be adequate for the future of young people as the nature of jobs and types of job expertise with market value change more quickly than schools can change their curricula.

-Evidence:

A recent McKinsey Global Institute study on skills in the age of automation argues that the future workforce will spend more time on activities that machines are less capable of, such as managing people, applying expertise, and communicating with others. The skills and capabilities required will also shift, requiring more social and emotional skills and more advanced cognitive capabilities, such

as logical reasoning and creativity. An experiment by Google's Project Oxygen found that the skills that top managers needed to succeed at Google were softer skills - trust, communication (especially listening skills), vision, productivity. Social and emotional-learning (SEL) skills are equally critical to students' future success on the job, giving students the tools through which they understand and manage their emotions, develop positive relationships, and feel empathy for others.

Link: The challenges facing young people to be ready for the future in terms of job preparedness are greater than they have been compared to the past as career success will require much more from them.

Most candidates did not use this point as a rebuttal/corresponding idea to the point above: could draw their attention to the value of it.

A2. Compared to the young in the past, the young today are far more empowered to speak up and initiate changes on an unprecedented level especially because they are digital natives and hence, are perceived to be far more ready to face the future with all its challenges.

- The rapid advancement in technology, particularly the internet, has opened up new ways of thinking and responding to global and regional events, giving young people today more opportunities to develop a stronger voice to participate in and to shape their responses to these events.

- Such opportunities provide important and relevant experiences to learn from each other and to prepare them for the future where they will be expected to take charge of their own decisions and also for others.

Example 1:

Greta Thunberg has attracted international attention since her lone demonstration outside the Swedish Parliament in August 2018. Her "school strike for the climate" has now grown into a global movement due to the widespread use of social media platforms by young people that has brought more than 10 million people onto streets worldwide to demand action on climate change.

Link: Young people today are actively participating in and responding to global issues with passion to bring about change, and this shows that they are better prepared to face the future that awaits them compared to their counterparts in the past who did not have such opportunities and tools at their disposal.

Example 2:

Malala Fund's Education Champion Network supports the work of educators and advocates and helps bolster girls' secondary education around the world. According to Malala: "We need to encourage girls that their voice matters. I think there are hundreds and thousands of Malalas out there." The girls they serve have high goals for themselves — and the organisation has high expectations for them to achieve their goals. The Malala Fund created Assembly, a digital publication and newsletter, as a platform for girls to speak out about the issues holding them back. In the next few years, the Malala Fund will significantly increase their investment in their network of education advocates and expand in up to 10 new countries, one or two every year.

Link: While the challenge to provide education for girls around the world is daunting, young people today are better equipped through technology and are ready to improve the world they live in, showing that they are more ready to face the future for themselves and their peers.

Most candidates did not include this point from this angle (see comment for last point below).

B2. However, young people today are experiencing higher levels of dissatisfaction with life in general because the forces against them such as governments and systemic forces are far stronger and they are ultimately powerless; therefore, they are more pessimistic, lacking readiness to face the challenges in the future.

- This is because young people are far more aware of how their governments and key organisations fail to deliver on their promises in spite of their efforts to initiate change in many areas, which dishearten them and they feel less ready to face the future with its complex challenges.

- Example 1: The series of student protests in the Middle East and North Africa which started in 2011 to push for greater democratisation is a case in point. Life for the young and old is still in turmoil because of the sweeping political and social changes taking place that provide no sense of stability.

- A majority in nine countries across the Arab world feel they are living in significantly more unequal societies today than before the Arab spring, an era of uprisings, civil wars and unsteady progress towards self-determination that commenced a decade ago, according to a Guardian-YouGov poll.

-The results of the far-reaching poll of 5,275 people across genders and age groups suggest the feelings of hopelessness and disfranchisement that have fuelled this turbulent chapter in the Middle East have only increased, even if most people do not regret the protest movements. Hence, young people do not feel more prepared for the future.

-Example 2: Thousands of young people across the world participated in protests to push for changes after George Floyd's death last March because of racism and police brutality towards the blacks. Yet, on a daily basis, such incidents still take place, leaving the young feeling disheartened with the deep-rooted systemic issues still taking a toll. They do not feel optimistic or more ready to face their future given such failure of their governments to rise to the challenges that have plagued their societies for a long time.

Apparently, this level of thinking is beyond the average candidate.

B3. The rampant use and reliance on social media platforms by young people today has led to problems of cyber-addiction, social isolation and a warped sense of reality linked to poorer social and psychological well-being which makes them less prepared to face future challenges.

-Life for young people today is filled with greater challenges in preparing for the future because the frequent use of social media heightens other socio-emotional risks such as lowered self-esteem. Also, young people are in the habit of comparing numbers of followers and likes, which results in many of them suffering from envy toward their peers. This negatively impacts their ability to be ready for the future.

Example: The Child Mind Institute in New York reported that the impossible standards (of perfection and popularity) are nowadays set not by celebrities and models but by classmates and friends....And there's evidence that those images are causing distress for many kids.... "the combined weight of vulnerability, the need for validation, and a desire to compare themselves with peers forms what can be known as a 'perfect storm of self-doubt'".

- This is especially true when compared to life in the past for young people where social media was not as extensively used as today. Hence, young people today face greater challenges in being ready for the future.

While many candidates included references to the use of social media by the young, it was used differently – that social media was a tool for empowerment.